exception; he had already been forced, more than once, to fight to defend his title; and now he decided to make a friend of the king of Meath. Together, the two drove Mac Murchada out of Leinster.

Mac Murchada, catching a favorable wind, went across the Irish Sea and appealed to the English throne for help. Henry II was himself in Western Francia, occupied in yet another struggle with Louis VII of France over control of his lands there; but he knew that anything that created chaos in Ireland was bound to be good for the English. He sent back a message giving all of his knights permission to help Mac Murchada recover his throne, and promising them "favour and licence" in exchange.[2]

The most prominent knight to take up the challenge was Richard de Clare, son of the Earl of Pembroke. Nicknamed "Strongbow" for his skill, de Clare had fought in his early twenties for King Stephen, against Henry's mother Matilda; and when Henry finally claimed the crown, he had refused to allow Richard to inherit the title of earl. Now, de Clare saw the chance to gain a crown instead. He agreed to fight for Mac Murchada in exchange for the chance to inherit the throne of Leinster; Mac Murchada's oldest daughter Aoife agreed to marry the Englishman, to seal the deal.

This arrangement worked out better for Richard than for his new father-in-law. By 1171, the English had helped Mac Murchada reoccupy his kingdom, but during the protracted struggle Mac Murchada's own son was killed, and Mac Murchada himself took ill and died in the first week of May, not long after his sixty-first birthday.

Strongbow and Aoife could now claim to be king and queen of Leinster, but Henry II—finally returning from Western Francia—intervened. He did not want one of his knights establishing an independent monarchy right across the water, and so he assembled an army at the western port city of Gloucester, ready to sail to Ireland. Strongbow, still fighting off the combined forces of the king of Meath and the High King, hurried to Gloucester and assured the king of his loyalty. "He succeeded at last . . . in appeasing the royal displeasure," says Gerald of Wales, "upon the terms that he should renew his oath of fealty to the king, and surrender to him Dublin . . . with the towns on the sea coast, and all the fortresses." Richard would rule as king of Leinster, but only by Henry's permission; and the English king would take direct control of the port cities.[3]

With this settled, Henry and his army sailed across to Ireland to help Richard drive off the High King's attacks. They landed at the southern port of Waterford on October 18, 1171, and marched north towards Dublin. Before they could arrive, most of the Irish kings had hurried to meet him and offer their submission. No single Irish kingdom could muster a force large enough